

THE HISTORY OF Sopot

From a Medieval Settlement to the Pearl of the Baltic

1. EARLY HISTORY AND FISHING VILLAGE

The history of settlement in the area of modern Sopot dates back to the 8th-10th centuries, when an early medieval stronghold (today's Grodzisko) existed here. The first historical mention of Sopot comes from 1283, when the Pomeranian Duke Mściwoj II donated this small fishing village to the Cistercian monks from nearby Oliwa. For the next few centuries, Sopot remained a quiet settlement, which from the 16th century began to attract wealthy patricians and diplomats from Gdansk, who built their summer residences here.

2. THE BIRTH OF THE RESORT (1823)

The breakthrough in the city's history occurred in 1823. It was then that Jean Georg Haffner, a former physician in Napoleon's army, built a professional bathing establishment in Sopot. Haffner also laid out the first walking paths, established the Southern and Northern Parks, and built the first wooden pier. Thanks to his vision, Sopot rapidly transformed into an elegant health resort (Zoppot), attracting visitors from all over Prussia and Europe.

3. DEVELOPMENT AND THE GOLDEN AGE

The completion of the railway line connecting Berlin to Krolewicz in 1870 made Sopot easily accessible to mass tourists. The turn of the 19th and 20th centuries was the resort's golden age. In 1901, Sopot was granted city rights. Luxury villas, casinos, and magnificent bathhouses were built. In 1909, the famous Forest Opera was opened. The city earned the nickname the "Riviera of the North," and its wooden pier was repeatedly extended, reaching impressive dimensions.

4. THE FREE CITY OF DANZIG (1920–1939)

After the end of World War I, under the Treaty of Versailles, Sopot was incorporated into the borders of the Free City of Danzig. During this period, the city continued to develop, and its local casino was particularly popular, generating enormous profits. It was with this money that the monumental Casino Hotel (today's Grand Hotel) was built in 1927, hosting the aristocratic and cultural elite from around the world.

5. WORLD WAR II

During World War II, Sopot was incorporated into the Third Reich. Unlike nearby Gdansk, the city survived the war without catastrophic destruction (only about 10% of its buildings were destroyed). In March 1945, the Red Army entered Sopot. Shortly thereafter, the city was handed over to the Polish administration, and the remaining German population was expelled.

6. POST-WAR CULTURAL CAPITAL

After the war, Sopot quickly regained its entertainment and cultural character. In 1961, Wladyslaw Szpilman initiated the International Song Festival (Sopot Festival) at the Forest Opera, which became one of the most important musical events in the Eastern Bloc. Modern Sopot is the vibrant heart of the Tricity, famous for the longest wooden pier in Europe, the famous "Monciak" promenade, and its unique spa atmosphere.